Catheters and feeding tubes: two different home-care plans

> You should be shown what to do, have a chance to practise, and know whom to call.

Urinary catheter care

Keep the bag below bladder level and avoid kinks or pressure on the tubing. Wash hands before and after handling equipment; follow instructions for daily skin hygiene and emptying. Do not copy a feeding-tube procedure for a urinary catheter.

When drainage stops

Check for an obvious kink and bag position. Persistent absent drainage, leakage, pain, blood or fever needs prompt professional help. Do not remove or flush the catheter without training and specific instructions. Follow your existing fluid plan rather than forcing extra drinks.

Feeding-tube safety

For a nasogastric tube, follow the taught position-check procedure before each use. If position is uncertain, do not give feed, medicines or water. Vomiting, displacement or new breathing symptoms requires advice. An external mark alone is not a complete placement check.

Use a written plan

Ask for the prescribed feed, volume, rate, position and flush instructions. Check with the pharmacist before crushing tablets. Do not force a blocked tube or invent a replacement schedule. Different devices need different care.

> ### Urgent changes
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> Fever, shivering, pain, obvious blood or a displaced catheter needs prompt contact. Stop feeding and obtain emergency help for severe breathing difficulty or loss of responsiveness.

> For a life-threatening emergency in India, call 112. Elsewhere use your local emergency number.

Questions you may have

Does a catheter mean unlimited fluids?

No. Kidney or heart disease may require a personal fluid plan.

What to remember

Correct device, correct instructions, demonstrated skills and an accessible contact number.

Sources and further reading

NHS — living with a urinary catheter
https://www.nhs.uk/tests-and-treatments/urinary-catheters/living-with/

NIDDK — healthy eating with chronic kidney disease
https://www.niddk.nih.gov/health-information/kidney-disease/chronic-kidney-disease-ckd/healthy-eating-adults-chronic-kidney-disease

Cambridge University Hospitals — tube feeding at home
https://www.cuh.nhs.uk/patient-information/tube-feeding-at-home/

Government of India — Emergency Response Support System 112
https://112.gov.in/about

Educational information supports understanding and does not replace individual medical care. Follow your clinician’s plan. Do not change medicines on your own. Sources checked: 24 October 2026.

Website: https://home-visiting-icu-doctor.vercel.app/#wikiSection
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